Terramation

Gently transforming a person into soil: what the process is, how long it takes, what comes back to you, and what it costs.

What comes back is soil

Terramation gently transforms a person into soil, not ashes. Washington calls it natural organic reduction; the news calls it human composting. Only straw, alfalfa and sawdust go into the vessel, with the oxygen that flows through it. No chemicals, nothing added to change the body. What comes back is clean, fertile soil, ready to be planted in, scattered, or placed at the cemetery.

We provide terramation through Return Home, a licensed funeral home and terramation facility in Auburn and a preferred partner of Bonney Watson. You make the arrangements with us; the transformation takes place at their facility. Their staff and ours have done this together many times.

How the Process Works

About two months, in two halves



The vessel, laid with straw, greenery and flowers. This is the same vessel the person stays in.

We bring your loved one into our care and bathe and dress them here in a compostable garment, then take them to Return Home. They are laid in a sealed, environmentally controlled vessel on a bed of straw, alfalfa and sawdust, and that's when a laying-in ceremony happens. Oxygen flows through the vessel for **about 30 days** while the body's own microbes do the work. The material is then screened to take out anything not organic, and the screened soil rests and cools for **about another 30 days**. Expect about two months; we keep you posted rather than promising a date, because the process is allowed to finish rather than run on a clock.

Is the soil safe to handle and to plant in? Washington regulates this rather than leaving it to the provider. Before soil can be released it must pass pathogen testing and contain less than 0.01 mg per kilogram dry weight of physical contaminants, a category that includes intact bone, dental fillings and medical implants. It comes back as clean, fertile soil, and families plant in it.

The Laying-In Ceremony

The goodbye, at the vessel

A laying-in ceremony is the terramation equivalent of a viewing. Your loved one lies in their vessel, on the bed of organics, and the family gathers around to say goodbye, **in person, virtually, or both**, with a live webcast and a video tribute. **You decide what goes in and on the vessel**: anything organic, so flowers, food, letters. Children often take an active part, and placing a flower gives a child something to do at a moment when there's otherwise nothing. Anyone may lead it, clergy of any faith or a family member. **The vessel is the real one**, not a facade, and it's where your loved one stays. You can visit during the first 30 days.

The ceremony is priced separately and is optional. Families who don't hold one still say goodbye with us in the ways they would for any other arrangement.

Receiving the Soil

There is more of it than most families expect. A full return is about **1 to 1.5 cubic yards**, typically about **250 pounds**, in breathable burlap bags, each tied with a hand-drawn tag carrying your loved one's name and dates. Bags come in sizes down to a mini holding a large handful, which is what families usually want for a keepsake or to give to several relatives. You may take all of it, some of it, or none. It can be collected, shipped or delivered anywhere in the US or Canada.

Any soil you don't take is scattered at **the Woodland**, an eight-acre protected greenbelt Return Home maintains in Kent, at no additional charge. **The Woodland isn't open for visits.** If having somewhere to go back to matters to your family, say so early, and see below.

Where the Soil May Go

What the law allows, and what we can offer at the cemetery

Permission is the rule. Your own garden is yours to plant. Anywhere else, whether it's a friend's land, a park or a stretch of forest, ask first.

Terramated remains can be placed at Washington Memorial Park, in a standard-size plot. That gives your family a permanent, cared-for place with a name on it that anyone can visit, which is the one thing scattering on private land can't give back later. Ask me and I'll set aside the time to walk you through it.

What It Costs

Two charges, from our General Price List

Terramation

Natural Organic Reduction, from the General Price List, Alternative Methods of Disposition

$7,795.00

Includes our basic services and staff, transfer into our care, bathing, the terramation itself, and use of a utility vehicle. It doesn't include staff or facilities for a visitation or ceremony.

Laying in Ceremony

Additional option, described above

$895.00

A video tribute, a live webcast, and two hours of Return Home's facility and staff for the ceremony and in-person goodbye.

What these two don't cover. Cemetery property, placement at the park, a marker, certified death certificates and shipping of the soil are all priced separately. Ask me for a written quote covering everything you are actually considering.

Both figures are taken verbatim from the Bonney Watson General Price List effective April 2026. Prices are subject to change without notice. Ask me for the complete price list.

Practical Matters

Eligibility, planning ahead, and how terramation became legal here

Who can be terramated. Nearly everyone. A small number of medical circumstances rule it out, and a person who has been embalmed can't be terramated. Rather than print a list that could be out of date by the time you read it, we check with Return Home directly before anything is arranged. Tell me what you know about the medical history and I'll confirm it for you.

Planning ahead. Terramation can be arranged and paid for ahead of time, like any other funeral plan, in full or on a payment plan. A prepaid arrangement can't be cancelled or substantially changed by your survivors, so your family won't

be left guessing. I can walk you through it.

How it became legal. Washington was **the first state in the United States** to legalize natural organic reduction. Senate Bill 5001 was signed by Governor Jay Inslee in May 2019 and took effect on **May 1, 2020**. It passed with votes from both parties. Several other states have legalized it since, and more are considering it.

TALKING IT OVER

- Bonney Watson makes the arrangements; the terramation takes place at Return Home in Auburn.
- Decide early whether your family wants a laying-in ceremony. It happens when the person is laid in the vessel, near the start.
- Decide roughly how much soil you want to receive, and whether any of it is going to the cemetery.
- If you want somewhere permanent to visit, ask about placement at Washington Memorial Park before the soil is returned.

Come and talk it through

Terramation is still new to most families, and there's no wrong question about it. I can walk you through what happens, what it costs alongside everything else, and whether placing the soil at Washington Memorial Park is right for you. There is no cost to ask and no obligation.

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